ERA 6

The Second Party System

1836 – 1840

Whigs vs. Democrats · the Panic of 1837 · the Log Cabin campaign

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did economic crisis and a new style of campaigning reshape American party politics?

KEY TERMS

Whig Party · Second Party System · Panic of 1837 · Specie Circular · Log Cabin campaign

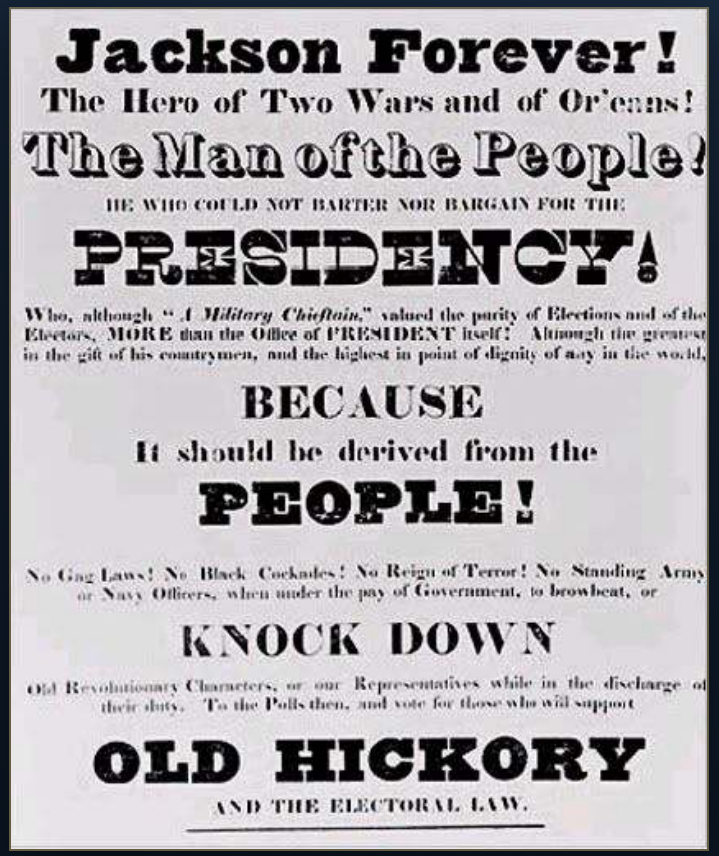
ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 4.7 · AMSCO Ch. 4.7

SECTION

A Mature Two-Party System

Democrats vs. Whigs


Jackson Forever!

The Hero of Two Wars and of Or'eans!

The Man of the People!

HE WHO COULD NOT BARTER NOR BARGAIN FOR THE

PRESIDENCY!

Who, although "*A Military Chieftain,*" valued the purity of Elections and of the Electors, MORE than the Office of PRESIDENT itself! Although the greatest in the gift of his countrymen, and the highest in point of dignity of any in the world,

BECAUSE

It should be derived from the

PEOPLE!

No Gag Laws! No Black Cockades! No Reign of Terror! No Standing Army or Navy Officers, when under the pay of Government, to browbeat, or

KNOCK DOWN

Old Revolutionary Characters, or our Representatives while in the discharge of their duty. To the Polls then, and vote for those who will support

OLD HICKORY

AND THE ELECTORAL LAW.

- By the 1830s a full **Second Party System** operated nationally.
- **Democrats** (Jackson) championed the **common man** and limited government.
- **Whigs** (Clay) favored an active government and the American System.

Two Visions of Government

The Democrats

Jackson's party

- Champions of the **common man**.
- Feared concentrated federal and financial power.
- Opposed the national bank and high tariffs.

The Whigs

Clay's party

- Favored an **active national government**.
- Backed Clay's American System—bank, tariff, roads.
- Drew merchants, reformers, and the Northeast.

SECTION

The Panic of 1837

Roots of the Panic

CAUSE

Bank War

Jackson destroys the national bank; credit runs wild through 'pet banks.'

→

TRIGGER

Specie Circular

Jackson demands gold/silver for federal land—drying up paper money.

→

COLLAPSE

Bubble Bursts

Land speculation collapses; banks fail across the country.

→

RESULT

Depression

A years-long depression—falling on new president Van Buren.

Van Buren's Burden

I

Inherited a Crisis

Martin Van Buren took office just as the Panic hit.

II

Limited Response

True to Democratic ideals, he kept government out of the economy.

III

Political Cost

Blamed for hard times, he became deeply unpopular.

SECTION

The Election of 1840

The Log Cabin Campaign

- The **Whigs** ran war hero **William Henry Harrison** as a man of the people.
- They flooded the country with **log cabin** and **hard cider** imagery.
- Slogans like '**Tippecanoe** and Tyler Too' won a landslide.



Politics Becomes a Spectacle

I

Image Over Issues

Harrison, a wealthy man, was sold as a humble frontiersman.

II

Mass Participation

Rallies, songs, and slogans drew huge crowds.

III

The Modern Campaign

1840 set the template for image-driven presidential races.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Second Party System

1. The **Second Party System** pitted Jackson's **Democrats** against Clay's **Whigs** in vigorous national competition.
2. The **Panic of 1837**—rooted in the Bank War and the **Specie Circular**—sank Van Buren's presidency.
3. The 1840 **Log Cabin campaign** made politics a mass spectacle and swept the **Whigs** into power.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Second Party System

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Trace how Jackson's **Bank War** helped cause the **Panic of 1837**.

COMPARISON

Compare the **Whig** and **Democratic** visions of government. Whose ideas better addressed the economic crisis?

CONTINUITY & CHANGE

How did the **Log Cabin campaign** of 1840 change the way Americans ran for president?

Up next — **Class 19: The Market Revolution** (technology, industry & immigration)